In this civil war, Henry Tudor emerged victorious and he started a new line of monarchy in England. He assumed the title Henry VII and entered into matrimonial alliance with Elizabeth of York family. This made England to emerge as a nation-state.

Henry VII decided to remove the threat of the nobles to his rule. The nobles maintained private armies with special insignia called livery and maintenance. On becoming the king, Henry abolished this practice. He took the support of the merchant class and a few minority nobles to pass laws in the parliament. He created a special court in the Star Chamber to put the rebellious nobles on trial. The kingdom collected money as fine from the nobles that increased the royal revenue. The parliament gave the king right to collect taxes too. Henry VII, who ruled between 1485 and 1509, established a firm control over the kingdom.

Livery was the system of giving badges or uniform to the followers of nobles. Maintenance was the system of protecting the interests of the followers by the nobles.

Star Chamber was the court of law created by Henry VII to try cases related to the property of the nobles. It is named after the stars painted on the ceiling of a room in Westminster Palace, where the proceedings of the court were conducted.

The king strengthened his ties with Scotland by giving his elder daughter in marriage to the Scottish prince. He maintained matrimonial relationship with the Spain too by making his son marry the princess of Spain.

France as Nation-State

Burgundy, situated to the east of France, was a powerful state. Though nominally vassal to the king of France, it was a turbulent vassal, and the English intrigued with it against France. A good part of western France was for long in English possession. The Valois dynasty, which was ruling France, fought to retain and retrieve the French territories from English control. There was what is called the Hundred Years' War between England and France from early in the fourteenth century to the middle of the fifteenth century. In this war, the French king Charles VII was helped by Joan of Arc, a young girl who fought courageously and won the battle at Orleans. Joan of Arc was given the title Maid of Orleans. However, she was captured by the English and tried by the court for her claim that she was guided by heavenly voices. She was condemned as a witch and burnt at the stakes in 1430. (In 1920, the Catholic Church conferred sainthood on her.)



Louis XI

After the death of Joan of Arc, the French continued the Hundred Years' War and emerged victorious. Having got the English out of his country, Louis XI, son of Charles VII, turned to Burgundy. This troublesome vassal was finally brought under control and Burgundy became part of France in about 1483. France became a strong centralised monarchy. Louis XI strengthened and unified France. For the first time in the history of France, a permanent army was created for the monarch without relying on the support from the nobles. His Royal Council had more lawyers than nobles, thus undermining the influence of the nobles in the royal affairs.

Summary

- Renaissance of Italy and its spread to western Europe are discussed.
- Renaissance in literature, art and science with special reference to prominent renaissance scholars, artists and scientists are described.
- Factors responsible for geographical discoveries of fifteenth and sixteenth century are explored.
- Leading role played by Portugal and Spain are highlighted.

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